

‘Let me show you the *mujra* hall before we leave. It is quite a sight, and you may be surprised by some of the faces in the audience,’ Lucky said.

I protested, saying I had seen enough for the evening. But Lucky was insistent.

‘Don’t be such a sissy. You have been quite irritating as it is. I introduced you to one of the girls who has turned down some of the big stars of the market, and you, like an idiot . . . never mind. Come along now!’ he almost ordered me in.

This is it, I thought, as we made our way through a narrow passage towards the *mujra* hall. He might just push me into one of the adjoining rooms, get some whores to strip me and pin me down on the bed, have all of us photographed and then blackmail me using those pictures for the rest of my life.

Finally we reached the *mujra* hall. The doorman said there would be no show that day. ‘Everybody is busy watching the match (there was a World Cup match that evening), business has been slack for the past few days,’ he said.

I was relieved.

At last, we stepped out into the sultry night.

‘You surprise me,’ Lucky said, as we took a stroll. ‘I thought you were like any other normal trader who has his indulgences.’

‘I am no saint, Lucky, but in matters of women I have stuck to one rule from the first time I had sex: I only eat what I kill; whores do not excite me,’ I told him.

I then asked Lucky if he enjoyed visiting dance bars.

‘Not really, but I have become a regular at some of these places without wanting to. When we have overseas fund managers visiting us, my boss asks me to show them some of the “happening places” in Mumbai. Of course, most of the fund managers are eager for such action. To get business from foreign fund houses, we have to keep the fund managers happy. After all, why should they place orders with any one particular broking firm in a trade where none of the firms have anything unique to offer?’ Lucky said.

I swore never to visit that place again, and certainly not with Lucky. But a few weeks later, when he again suggested that we meet over a drink at White House, I agreed without the slightest reluctance.

‘But don’t create a scene like the last time,’ he told me with some irritation. ‘And I must tell you this – Payal seems to have taken a shine to